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Editing

Attention 2

Release

→ Dr. Lurié Article Agent · via CMS [edit directly](#)

DL Agent

Comment — a question, a change, an ask

Retinol Without the Flake · Published · Aug 2

Retinol Without the Flake: A Realistic On-Ramp

A four-week protocol that gets sensitive skin onto retinoids without the peeling, panic, or product graveyard.

Aug 2, 2026 · Dr. N. Lurié · Skincare · retinol sensitive-skin ≈ \$1.42 · 3 runs

1 Most people quit retinol in week two — not because it doesn't work, but because nobody told them the flaking is the process working too fast. The fix isn't a gentler product. It's a slower door.

Why the first fortnight fails

Retinoids accelerate cell turnover before the skin barrier has adapted its lipid production. The result is predictable: dryness around day four, visible flaking by day nine, and a bathroom cabinet gaining another abandoned tube. Dermatology literature has a name for the adaptation window — retinization — and a boring, reliable way through it.

- ✓ You've tried retinol before and stopped within a month.
- ✓ Your skin stings after ordinary moisturizer on some days.
- ✓ You want results by autumn, not by Friday.

figure — barrier adaptation timeline

The adaptation window: irritation peaks in week two, then falls as barrier lipids catch up.

1 The two-night rule · draft

Start with two non-consecutive nights a week, a pea-sized amount over moisturizer — yes, over. The buffering slows absorption enough for the barrier to keep pace. Hold two weeks, then add a third night only if the previous week was calm.

The 4-Week Retinol On-Ramp, printable

The full night-by-night calendar, the buffering technique, and the "stop and hold" signals — free,

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